Region (IOR) as the Chinese presence in the region has increased dramatically over the last decade. But weak political leadership in India circumscribed the India–US relationship.

The Modi factor

Under Prime Minister Modi, Indo–US relations have witnessed a qualitative shift. Even though all Prime Ministers before Modi attempted to build a strong partnership with the United States, the tone and tenor of Modi's US outreach has been remarkably different. For one, Indian foreign policy appears to have shunned the ambivalence of yesteryears; the new leadership remains unhindered by the ideological baggage of non-alignment.[29] Modi's personalised diplomacy has added a new flavour to the bilateral relationship. His personal equation with Presidents Obama and Trump notwithstanding, he has been equally emphatic in building relations with the Congress and the Senate. The bipartisan support for the bilateral relationship on Capitol Hill is a testament to India's efforts under the new leadership. Unlike his predecessors, Modi also appears to be a problem solver: the alacrity with which the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) and the Ministry of Defence (MoD) have responded to many challenges such as the civil nuclear liability and defence cooperation agreements is an important contrast to the previous regime.

The election of Narendra Modi as India's Prime Minister in May 2014 was the decisive jolt that the Indo–US relationship needed. Within three months of assuming office, he had his first summit-level meeting with President Obama. Contrary to popular opinion that Modi would be unable to leave behind his uncomfortable relationship with the United